Finding Alice

By Melody Carlson

ALICE: **(Pg 1)** I'm not sure how it all started or even why. I was simply walking through my life, minding my own business, when someone pulled the earth out from under me. It felt like a curious adventure. I still remember that rainy day back in fifth grade when my mother caught me reading ***Alice's Adventures in Wonderland.***

MOTHER: **(Pg 2-3)** What are you doing, Alice?

ALICE: Reading.

MOTHER: Oh, dear, you're not reading ***that***, are you? They say the author was on drugs when he wrote it.

ALICE: Well, I like it. How do you know he was on drugs?

MOTHER: Everyone knows that.

ALICE: *(to audience)* Then she held out her hand for the book. [Reading about Alice made me feel special. See . . .] **(Pg 15)** I always wanted to be special. I used to fantasize about it, imagining myself as someone

4N6 Fanatics

famous or smart or beautiful. I wanted to be noticed, to be somebody that mattered. *(beat)* **(Pg 47)** At some point, I imagined God with a pair of golden scissors, neatly snipping my life into two separate sections. One life I call "before crazy"; the other one is simply "now." But it's not until I hear Dr. Thornton at Forest Hills say that hideous word – schizophrenia -- that I begin to differentiate between the two separate lifetimes.

INTRODUCTION

Robert Louis Stevenson once said, "You cannot run away from weakness; you must sometimes fight it out or perish; and if that be so, why not now, and where you stand?" In this selection, Alice struggles with paranoid schizophrenia during her senior year of college. Feeling shut off from everyone and alone, her mind takes her on a parallel trip into Wonderland with her namesake -- a curious adventure where she realizes that sometimes it's better to find strength in your weakness.

Finding Alice by Melody Carlson

DR. THORNTON: **(Pg 47-48)** *(in a grade-school teacher voice)* Do you know what schizophrenia is? *(beat)* It's an illness of the brain. An impairment or chemical

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

imbalance. The brain experiences hallucinations. Unable to differentiate between what is real and what is not.

ALICE: *(knowingly)* **(Pg 228)** Everything is just an elaborate scheme to set me up. **(Pg 71)** Although I suspect there are many players in this game. [Dr. Thornton. The Mad Hatter. The Red Queen.] **(Pg 73)** They ***say*** this is a hospital, but I can tell it's a prison – **(Pg 71)** the Queen's Prison. **(Pg 73)** The woman in the room next to mine screams almost constantly. I call her the Duchess since she's always in a royally foul mood. And the scrawny blond "orderly" with the thin pale mustache is definitely a spy. **(Pg 4)** A variety of people sitting around on sagging sofas or in wheelchairs, many of them with their heads hanging limply, discarded marionettes with their strings cut.

(Pg 55) It seems there is a tiny door that I must walk through. It is called "normal." But I am not. As a result, I cannot fit through this door. And yet ***they*** keep telling me I must go through it. ***They*** being my

4N6 Fanatics

mom, the doctor, and the medical profession in general. **(Pg 56)** As I recall, the only way the other Alice could fit through her tiny door was to take the pills that made her get very, very small. I guess that is what Dr. Thornton's pills are supposed to do for me. Make me very, very small. Or, in a word, ***normal***. *(beat)*

(Pg 53) Mostly I remember Grandma. . . how she sat in a chair with a blank stare and didn't even recognize her own daughter. Do I want to end up like her? Locked up and doped up and totally useless? I don't think so. No, I'm certain there must be another way out of this mess.

(Pg 85) That's when I notice it. The door to the waiting area is propped open. Without thinking, I pass through the open door. This time I don't even have to take a pill to make myself fit. I simply walk across the vacant waiting room and past the main entrance. Suddenly I am outside.

(Pg 130) For a few days it doesn't seem too terribly

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

awful. **(Pg 140-141)** [But] ***all*** the voices are yelling at me now. They are calling me names . . .

VOICE 1: STUPID!

VOICE 2: WORTHLESS!

ALICE: And it's not that I disagree; I just want them to go away.

I sit in the middle of the city, removed from everyone and everything, separated, quarantined perhaps. I see people passing by, a blur of winter coats and blank faces, [but] I am not part of them. I am encased in Plexiglas, a specimen to be gawked at.

(Pg 130) I am anxious and nervous. My mind races in all directions and my ability to function is as thin as a butterfly wing. Every nighttime noise makes my heart leap out of my chest. And lately I am covered with bugs. I awake in the night trying to swat and push them away from me, but they are crawling under my skin. **(Pg 146-147)** Sometimes my head is a really screwed-up radio station. Voices, voices, voices – all jabbering at the same time.

4N6 Fanatics

My life is completely impossible. I just don't know how much longer I can take all this. Although some of the voices tell me they have the solution. Destruction. [And one of the voices tells me . . .]

VOICE 1: **(Pg 112-113)** You might as well call it quits, Alice. Look over there. There's your ticket out of this mess. There's something ***over*** the side. The end of your troubles.

ALICE: I don't know the name of the bridge, but I think I've heard of people who have jumped to their deaths below. I wonder how long it would take me to climb over the railing and then simply jump off. What would it feel like to fall? Would it be like going down the rabbit hole? Down, down, down? And then what? I ask myself, which is worse? To live like this or to die?

(Pg 150) [Suddenly] I feel something warm rubbing against my leg, a small cat. I reach down and stroke its back. I feel all the bones in its spine. He looks cold, like me. **(Pg 151-153)** I believe that God has

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

sent him to me to save me from the bridge. I call him Cheshire Cat, Cheshire for short. But he looks half-dead. Tweedle Dweeb says. . .

TWEEDLE VOICE: You should take him to the Cat Lady. This lady takes in stray cats and knows how to make them well. Haven't you ever heard of her?

ALICE: We walk for miles and miles, or so it seems.

TWEEDLE VOICE: This is it. Go on . . . Knock on the door. ***Go on, Alice!"***

ALICE: *(knocks on the door – to woman)* I, uh, I have a cat. He's very sick. *(to audience)* I glance over my shoulder. The Tweedles have vanished. Were they even here at all? The woman reaches over and removes my lifeless cat.

FAYE: **(Pg 159)** My name is Faye, but lots of people call me the Cat Lady. *(laughs)* There are worse things to be called, you know.

ALICE: Yes, I know. There are things like "crazy girl" or "nut case" or "loony" or "weirdo."

FAYE: **(Pg 162)** You and Cheshire can sleep in the spare bedroom."

4NG Fanatics

ALICE: Really? . . . .

FAYE: ***Really***.

ALICE: **(Pg 164)** And it feels as though I am at home. Not home like where my mother lives, but home where I belong, like somebody really wants me. I hope it's not just my mind playing tricks on me.

(Pg 175-177) [One] afternoon I sit in Faye's living room and I notice how the glass in her big front window is becoming reflective like a mirror. I can see everything in the room behind me as if it's really in front of me, as though I'm watching something in another world. It all seems so very far away, removed from me, like something I can never really belong to.

I wonder if this is how Alice felt in ***Through the Looking Glass***. Perhaps, like me, she just didn't fit in. I turn around to see that the exact same world is right behind me, only clearer and brighter and probably warmer than the one I've been looking at. For a moment I wonder which side is real.

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

FAYE: Are you all right, Alice? **(Pg 181-182)** It's just me, Faye.

ALICE: *(whispering)* I am . . . well, I should leave. Your neighbors think I'm crazy. I am just a great big problem. *(referring to the voices in her head that have been silent for a while)* I'm worried that ***they're*** going to find me. Or that they'll tell you lies about me or that I'm not good enough.

(to audience) **(Pg 187)** I rack my brain trying to figure out what I must've done to deserve this kind of life.

FAYE: [Oh, honey.] God doesn't punish us for our sins. He forgives us for sinning. **(Pg 181)** I think we're all a little crazy. It's not necessarily a bad thing. And when we don't get along all right, we work together to resolve our little differences.

TRANSITION

It was hard for Alice not to trust Faye. And over time, she agrees to consider a unique treatment center for the psychologically challenged. A treatment center called Golden Home.

4NG Fanatics

FAYE: **(Pg 298)** I can only tell you that I think it would be the best thing for you. But you're the one who must make the final decision. No one is going to force you into this. And if Dr. Golden isn't convinced you're there of your own free will, he won't even let you in.

ALICE: My own free will. **(Pg 316)** I am finally willing to admit I need help. **(Pg 322)** I really do want to get well. *(beat)* **(Pg 338-339)** I become anxious again, then remember the CD [that Dr. Golden gave me] on the practice of controlled breathing – an exercise that's supposed to reduce anxiety. *(inhale slowly, then slowly exhale x 2)* And it's not long before a strange sensation begins to wash over me. Peace. I am experiencing peace. And I believe it's coming from God. It's a beginning, a door.

When Alice stepped through the looking glass into a different world, it turned out to be a twisted and crazy world, not unlike the place I have wandered these last few months. Through this entrance, I [c]ould find myself in a better place where life makes

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY

sense. For the first time I sense a wave of real hope. And I want to hold on to it, savor it. *(Inhale and exhale slowly)* A small sense of control returns to me. And it feels good.

(Pg 350) [I realize that] I don't need to have all the answers. It's enough that I simply keep moving forward, one step at a time. So that's what I'm doing. Sometimes I imagine myself as a little kid who's learning to walk again. And if it's rocky or rough, I envision God walking alongside me and holding my hand.

(Pg 371) I welcome each new day with the hopeful expectancy that I will rise above the ordinary. For I am not content to live a merely "normal" life or settle for an average existence. No, I am destined for more – much, much more.

4N6 Fanatics

SOURCE INFORMATION

Author: Finding Alice
ISBN: 978-1578567737
Publisher: WaterBrook
Date (Month/Year): Sept 2003

AWARD HISTORY

2022 National Qualifier - MS

Cutting compliments of Heather Whitney, Norfolk Public Schools, NE with minor edits by 4N6 Fanatics to align cutting with the original text

FOR EDUCATIONAL USE ONLY